

US Markets Daily Report

Tuesday, August 18, 2026 | Market Close (5:07 PM ET)

■ DATA AVAILABILITY NOTICE: The network egress proxy in this execution environment blocked all external financial data sources on 2026-08-18 (Yahoo Finance, Reuters, CNBC, Bloomberg, MarketWatch, Barchart, Stooq). Today's closing prices for SPY and QQQ could not be fetched. The snapshot table reflects 2026-08-17 (last verified close). All market-move analysis and next-day scenarios are grounded in verified prior data and the known scheduled catalysts for today.

SPY / QQQ Snapshot (Last Verified Close: Aug 17, 2026)

ETF	Last Close (Aug 17)	vs Aug 14 Close	1Y High	1Y Low	~1Y Return
SPY	\$772.25	-0.52%	\$777.88	\$639.42	+20.55%
QQQ	\$728.40	-0.32%	\$745.00	\$574.22	+26.85%

Recent 10-Session Price Trend (verified from prices.csv):

Date	SPY Close	SPY Δ	QQQ Close	QQQ Δ
2026-08-04	\$771.64	+2.09%	\$726.39	+4.38%
2026-08-05	\$769.76	-0.24%	\$723.85	-0.35%
2026-08-06	\$769.40	-0.05%	\$722.40	-0.20%
2026-08-07	\$773.49	+0.53%	\$720.55	-0.26%
2026-08-10	\$772.72	-0.10%	\$718.39	-0.30%
2026-08-11	\$773.03	+0.04%	\$720.87	+0.35%
2026-08-12	\$774.61	+0.20%	\$727.35	+0.90%
2026-08-13	\$777.88	+0.42%	\$731.07	+0.51%
2026-08-14	\$776.32	-0.20%	\$730.74	-0.05%
2026-08-17	\$772.25	-0.52%	\$728.40	-0.32%

Note: Aug 18 row absent — live data fetch blocked by network policy. Aug 17 close is last verified entry in prices.csv.

News & Market Context — August 18, 2026

Live news feeds were unavailable (proxy blocked). The following analysis draws on the verified context from the Aug 17 report and the known scheduled events for today.

1. Home Depot (HD) Q2 Earnings — Released Before Market Open

HD was the dominant scheduled catalyst today. Consensus: EPS ~\$4.73, Revenue ~\$47.1B. The Aug 17 report's retail sales data (−0.6% MoM July) and the consumer sentiment backdrop set a cautious bar. If HD matched/beat, it would have partially offset the retail-sales narrative dragging consumer discretionary. If it missed — particularly on comp-store sales or forward guidance — it would have amplified the consumer slowdown fear that triggered Monday's broad market pullback (SPY −0.52%). The sector read-through to Lowe's, Target, Walmart, and Home Improvement REITs (e.g., Tanger, Regency) was significant.

2. July Housing Starts & Building Permits — 8:30 AM ET

Prior month: Starts ~1.37M, Permits ~1.44M. With 30-year mortgage rates still elevated (30-yr Treasury yield near 4.95%, the highest since 2007), a weak print would validate housing slowdown fears. A stronger-than-expected print is ambiguous: positive for homebuilders (LEN, DHI, PHM) but potentially inflationary via construction materials (lumber, copper). Either direction would have moved homebuilder stocks $\pm 2\text{--}4\%$.

3. July Industrial Production — 9:15 AM ET (Federal Reserve Release)

Manufacturing sector had been holding up despite consumer weakness. A miss here ($IP < -0.1\%$) combined with the weak retail sales print from Monday would create a synchronized-slowdown signal that historically triggers defensive rotation (utilities, healthcare, bonds) and growth sector selling. A beat would have provided relief and partially recovered Monday's SPY decline.

4. US-Iran Ceasefire Status

The 60-day ceasefire between the US and Iran was at its expiry window as of Aug 17. Brent crude had surged to ~\$89/bbl on Aug 17 as the naval blockade threatened to continue indefinitely. Today's diplomatic developments would have had material market impact: a ceasefire extension would release oil price pressure (potentially $-3\text{--}5\%$ Brent) and relieve long-yield concerns; an escalation would spike oil, push yields further, and weigh broadly on SPY/QQQ.

5. 30-Year Treasury Yield Trend

Monday's close near 4.95% (highest since 2007) was the single largest macro pressure factor on equity multiples — particularly on long-duration growth assets (tech, high-P/E) and REITs. Any intraday relief in yields (from weak economic data or diplomatic de-escalation) would have provided a partial equity bid. Watch for TIPS breakevens: if real yields rise but breakevens fall, it signals slowing growth + sticky inflation — the most punishing scenario.

News → Estimated Market Moves (Aug 18, 2026)

Because today's closing prices are unavailable, this section provides the analytical framework for what drove today's market, based on scheduled catalysts:

HD Earnings (dominant individual catalyst):

A beat would have added $+0.3\text{--}0.6\%$ to SPY (consumer confidence offset to Mon's retail sales miss). A miss would have subtracted $-0.4\text{--}0.7\%$ as it confirms the consumer slowdown signal. QQQ sensitivity is lower (HD is not a Nasdaq constituent); mostly SPY/DJIA driven.

Housing Starts / Industrial Production (macro layer):

Strong prints: $+0.1\text{--}0.3\%$ on both SPY and QQQ — removes one leg of the bear thesis. Weak both: $-0.3\text{--}0.5\%$ amplifying stagflation risk. Split (one strong/one weak): market likely shrugged — directionally flat.

Iran/Geopolitics (yield/oil driver):

Diplomacy resolution: SPY $+0.5\text{--}0.8\%$, QQQ $+0.6\text{--}1.0\%$ as oil releases and 30-yr yield retreats. Escalation: SPY $-1\text{--}1.5\%$, QQQ $-0.8\text{--}1.2\%$ from compounding yield spike and risk-off flight.

Net directional bias (pre-data, based on Aug 17 setup):

SPY had two headwinds (high yields, weak consumer) vs one tailwind (HD beat probability at $\sim 52\%$). QQQ's relative cushion came from AI semi and cloud exposure. Baseline: SPY likely in the range of -0.5% to $+0.5\%$; QQQ in -0.3% to $+0.5\%$. High variance event — the Iran headline alone could swing $\pm 1\%$.

Top Movers — Daily, Weekly, Monthly

Individual stock data for Aug 18 is unavailable. The following reflects last available verified data from Aug 17 and prior reports.

Daily Movers — August 17, 2026 (last verified)

#	Ticker	Company	Chg	Sector
G1	TMUS	T-Mobile US	+5.67%	Communication Services
G2	ROP	Roper Technologies	+3.44%	Industrials
G3	IFF	Int'l Flavors & Fragrances	+2.94%	Materials
G4	LMT	Lockheed Martin	+2.46%	Defense
G5	DOV	Dover Corporation	+2.22%	Industrials
G6	RTX	RTX Corp (Raytheon)	+1.74%	Defense
G7	CSCO	Cisco Systems	+1.49%	Technology
G8	CAT	Caterpillar	+0.70%	Industrials
G9	GS	Goldman Sachs	+0.31%	Financials
G10	XOM	ExxonMobil	+0.25%	Energy
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L1	MCHP	Microchip Technology	-3.06%	Semiconductors
L2	MCD	McDonald's	-1.81%	Consumer Discret.
L3	UNH	UnitedHealth Group	-1.63%	Healthcare
L4	MSFT	Microsoft	-1.09%	Technology
L5	V	Visa Inc.	-0.88%	Financials
L6	AMZN	Amazon	-0.82%	Consumer/Tech
L7	JNJ	Johnson & Johnson	-0.74%	Healthcare
L8	COST	Costco	-0.68%	Consumer Staples
L9	NVDA	Nvidia	-0.44%	Semiconductors
L10	GOOG	Alphabet	-0.41%	Communication Svcs

Daily sector theme — Gainers: Defense & Industrials (geopolitical premium + oil at \$89), T-Mobile (spectrum deal catalyst). Losers: Semis, Consumer, Healthcare, Long-duration Tech — weak retail sales + high 30-yr yield combination created a broad-based risk-off rotation.

Weekly Movers — Week of Aug 11–15, 2026

#	Ticker	Company	Chg	Sector
G1	SNDK	Sandisk	+15.0%	Semiconductors / AI Memory
G2	DDOG	Datadog	+11.5%	Cloud / Software
G3	APA	APA Corp	+~5.0%	Energy (Upstream)
G4	MU	Micron Technology	+~5.6%	Semiconductors
G5	MPC	Marathon Petroleum	+~4.0%	Energy / Refining
G6	PSX	Phillips 66	+~3.5%	Energy / Refining
G7	LMT	Lockheed Martin	+~3.2%	Defense
G8	TMUS	T-Mobile US	+~2.8%	Communication Svcs
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L1	COHR	Coherent Corp	−14.2%	Photonics / Optical
L2	LITE	Lumentum Holdings	−6.0%+	Photonics
L3	CIEN	Ciena Corp	−~4.0%	Networking
L4	MCHP	Microchip Technology	−~3.5%	Semiconductors
L5	UNH	UnitedHealth Group	−~2.8%	Healthcare

Weekly sector theme — Gainers: AI memory (Sandisk, Micron on AI demand narrative + PPI cool), Energy (oil surge), Defense (Iran risk). Losers: Optical/Photonics (OpenAI customer risk cascading through AI infrastructure ecosystem after Datadog's Q2 disclosure), rate-sensitive Healthcare.

Monthly Movers — July 2026

#	Ticker	Company	Chg (Jul)	Sector
G1	VREX	Varex Imaging	+48.0%	Healthcare / Med-Tech (M&A)
G2	MAX	MarineMax	+46.0%	Consumer Discret. (M&A)
G3	CTSH	Cognizant Technology	+42.9%	IT Services
G4	ACN	Accenture	+34.9%	IT Consulting
G5	PYPL	PayPal Holdings	+32.5%	Fintech
G6	IBM	IBM Corp	+~18%	IT Services / Cloud
G7	INFY	Infosys	+~15%	IT Services
G8	WIT	Wipro	+~12%	IT Services
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L1	CSGP	CoStar Group	−56% YTD	Real Estate Data
L2	SNDK	Sandisk	−46.6%	Semiconductors
L3	GLW	Corning	−45.9%	Photonics / Glass
L4	KLAC	KLA Corporation	−39.4%	Semiconductor Equipment
L5	LRCX	Lam Research	−~30%	Semiconductor Equipment

Monthly sector theme — Gainers: IT Services/Consulting (AI re-rating: incumbents now viewed as complements to AI, not victims; CTSH, ACN, IBM re-rated sharply upward). M&A pops (Varex, MarineMax). Fintech recovery (PYPL). Losers: AI infrastructure unwind — crowded AI semi and photonics positions reversed as institutions rotated out of capex-overhang plays. GLW, KLAC fell on extrapolation risk in AI datacenter build-out expectations.

Next-Day Scenarios — August 19, 2026 (Wednesday)

1. Lowe's (LOW) Q2 Earnings — Before Market Open

→ **BEAT (EPS > \$4.45, comp-sales > −1.5%, raised guidance):**

LOW +4–7%. Removes the 'big-box home improvement' bear thesis established by weak retail sales. SPY +0.2–0.4%; QQQ minimal. Home Depot's result (today) and Lowe's together create the read-through for Target and Walmart (reporting Thu). Sector bid for homebuilders (LEN, DHI) on the premise that consumer has more resilience than feared.

→ **MISS or weak guidance (comp-sales < −3%, EPS < \$4.30):**

LOW −5–8%. Compounds the consumer slowdown narrative. SPY −0.3–0.5%; adds weight ahead of Target/Walmart Thu. REITs, mall operators further pressured. Consumer staples defensively outperform;

Treasuries likely bid.

→ **In-line, cautious guidance:**

LOW $\pm 2\%$; market neutral. Watch what management says about the back-half outlook — guidance language matters more than the number.

2. FOMC Meeting Minutes (July meeting) — 2:00 PM ET

→ **Hawkish surprise (3+ members wanting rate hike, inflation concern dominant):**

Immediate sell-off — SPY -0.5 – -0.8% , QQQ -0.6 – -1.0% . 2-year Treasury yield spikes. Dollar strengthens. Gold/bonds rally (flight to quality). High-P/E tech (MSFT, NVDA, META) underperform as real rate expectations reset. This would be the week's worst catalyst if combined with weak earnings.

→ **Dovish tilt (data-dependent, hold bias, concern about over-tightening):**

Relief rally — SPY $+0.4$ – $+0.6\%$, QQQ $+0.5$ – $+0.8\%$. Rate-sensitive sectors (REITs, utilities) bounce. Growth tech re-rates modestly. Dollar softens. Gold holds. Most likely scenario given July CPI/PPI were both softer than June.

→ **Neutral/expected (split committee, data-dependency reiterated):**

Minimal reaction $\pm 0.2\%$. Market had priced in a 9-3 hawkish split from Aug 17 reporting; if confirmed without surprises, no major repricing.

3. US-Iran Diplomatic Status — Ongoing

→ **Ceasefire formally extended or progress toward deal:**

Brent crude -3 – -5% to $\sim \$84$ – $\$86$ /bbl. 30-yr Treasury yield retreats toward 4.75 – 4.85% . SPY $+0.5$ – $+0.9\%$, QQQ $+0.6$ – $+1.0\%$. Defense names (LMT, RTX) give back 1 – 2% of geopolitical premium. Airlines, logistics stocks recover. Risk appetite returns broadly.

→ **Ceasefire collapses / US escalates naval action:**

Brent $+5$ – $+8\%$ toward $\$93$ – $\$96$ /bbl. 30-yr yield spikes to $5.0\%+$ — multi-year milestone. SPY -1.0 – -1.5% , QQQ -0.8 – -1.2% . Energy sector (XLE) adds 2 – 4% . Defense stocks spike. Gold, Treasuries (flight to quality). This is the tail-risk scenario that would materially re-price the market's Sept Fed hike expectations.

4. Target (TGT) & Walmart (WMT) Q2 Earnings — Thursday Pre-Market (Tomorrow+1)

→ **Both beat (TGT: EPS $> \$2.00$; WMT: EPS $> \$0.73$ per ADS):**

Closes the loop on consumer health — if Lowe's Wed and WMT/TGT Thu all beat, the retail-sales miss (-0.6%) looks like a statistical anomaly rather than a trend. SPY $+0.5$ – $+1.0\%$ on Thursday open. Consumer sector rerate. The 'soft landing' narrative gets its data points.

→ **Both miss or cite traffic/volume weakness:**

Validates the recession signal. SPY -0.8 – -1.2% on Thursday. Consumer discretionary and staples both sell. The week-long consumer data cascade (retail sales $\rightarrow$ HD $\rightarrow$ LOW $\rightarrow$ WMT/TGT) would constitute the most synchronized consumer weakness evidence since early 2024.

Possible Trade Summary — End of Day Aug 18 / Aug 19 Open

Analysis grounded in verified price trends, scheduled catalysts, and sector context. Not financial advice. No trades placed or simulated.

Action	Ticker	Rationale	Conviction
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BUY-IF-BEAT	LOW	If Home Depot (today) beats and Lowe's (Wed) shows resilient High conditional. Risk-reward: +5–7% beat	
HOLD/ADD	LMT / RTX	Iran tensions are not resolved. Defense sector has a durable geopolitical premium as long as ceasefire status	
REDUCE	COHR / LITE	Photonics/optical infrastructure stocks facing structural pressure. Medical capex expectations were over-extrapolated	
CAUTIOUS BUY	XOM / CVX	Brent at \$89 is direct revenue tailwind for integrated majors. If Iran's activities (XLE dependency) provides con	
AVOID NEW POSITIONS	SPX	The index is caught between two opposing forces: strong 1Y return (20.55%) argues for staying long; however	
WATCH	MSFT / META / GOOGL	Big-cap tech fell modestly on Aug 17 on yield pressure. These are (average duration ~50M sensitive) real rat	
AVOID	UNH / managed care	Rate headwinds on investment portfolio + Medicaid utilization concerns. No near-term catalyst. The sector's c	

Report date: 2026-08-18 | Data source: prices.csv (Jul 2025–Aug 17, 2026) | ■ Aug 18 live prices unavailable — network egress proxy blocked all financial data sources. | Not financial advice.